
SPRING 2026

SOC 102

social

PROBLEMS

Professor: Burrell Vann Jr

Room: AH-3127

Day & Time: Tuesdays: 4:00PM - 6:40PM

Schedule #: 11680

DESCRIPTION

What counts as a social problem? Are classism, racism, sexism, or heteronormativity types of social problems? What about our enduring crises, such as homelessness, opioid abuse, drug addiction, or inequalities in our systems of education, criminal justice, or healthcare?

In this course, we will learn to identify and explain social problems in society. We answer these questions and develop an understanding of various solutions through policy and social action. We will draw on empirical evidence, as well as current events, to demonstrate the real manifestations of social problems as well as their effective solutions.

OBJECTIVES

By the end of the course, students should be able to:

1. Understand how systems of power create social problems
2. Critically examine social problems, and how they are interconnected and socially-constructed
3. Synthesize how social problems affect different communities
4. View themselves as social actors and agents of change
5. Identify organizations devoted to solving pressing social problems

CONTACT

Professor: Burrel Vann Jr

Email: bvannjr@sdsu.edu

Office: <https://SDSU.zoom.us/j/81468538945>

Office Hours: By appointment only, on Mondays: 1:00pm-2:00pm

EMAIL POLICY:

When emailing about the course, please provide the course number and time. I check email twice per day, Monday through Friday, between 9:00am and 5:00pm. Please allow up to 72 hours for a response.

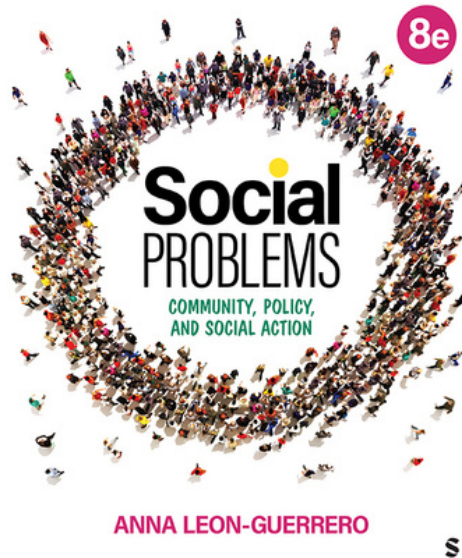
Requesting Help:

If you miss a class meeting, you should: First, look on the course website for material you missed. Second, if you need help understanding material, you should contact your classmates via the course Slack channel or Canvas (direct email or discussion board). Third, if you still find it difficult, email me to schedule an appointment chat with me during Zoom office hours. For office hours, I require 1-week notice to schedule a meeting.

Requesting Non-Office-Hours Zoom Meetings:

If you still need help but cannot attend office hours, you may email me to request a meeting. For Non-Office-Hours Zoom meetings, I require a minimum of 1-week notice.

MATERIALS



BOOK

REQUIRED

Articles & Book Chapters

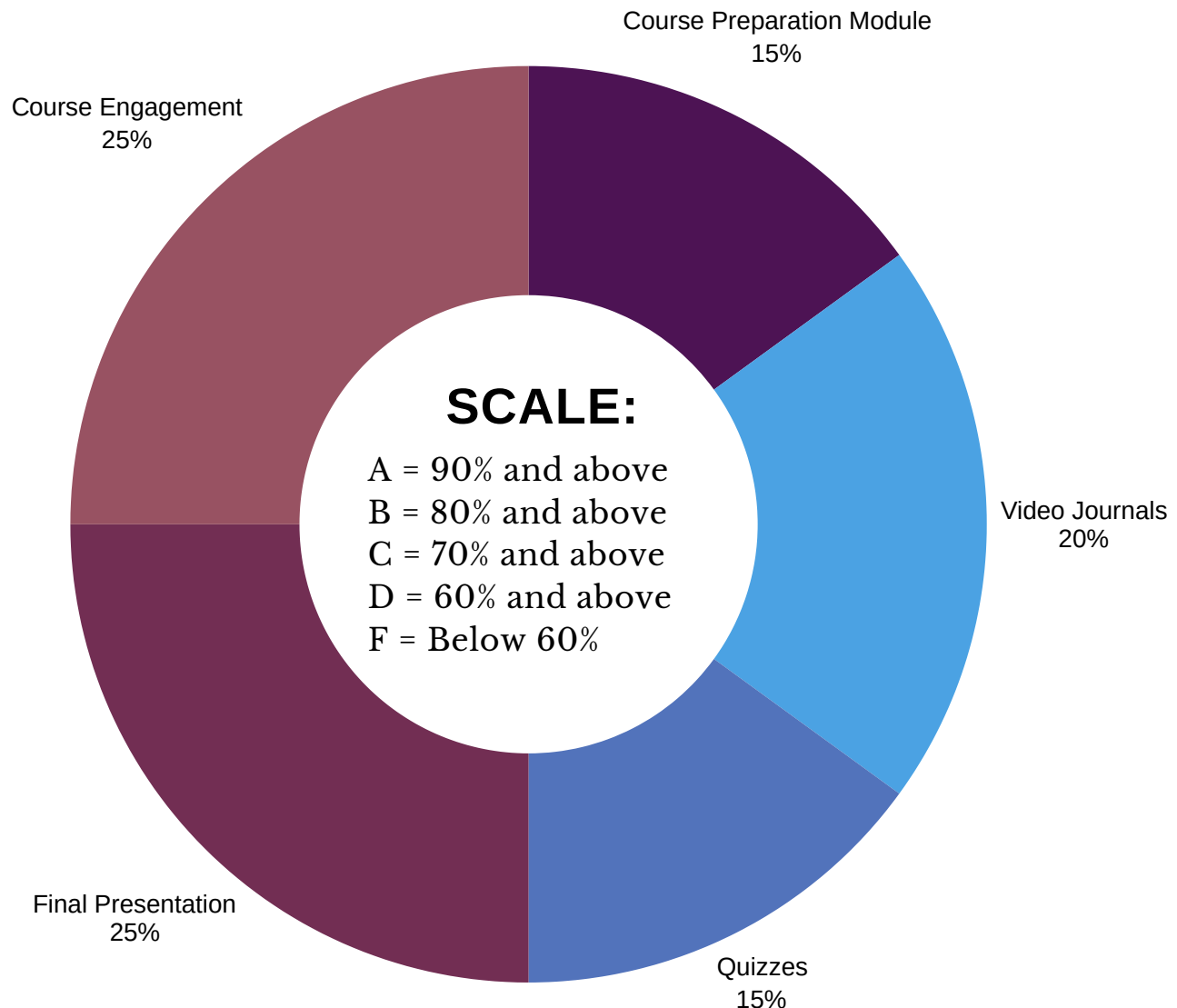
TECHNOLOGY ACCESS:

To be successful in this class, students will be required to have access to a computer with an internet connection and Google Drive.

- **Computer w/ Internet Access:**
 - Students must be able to access the course material.
- **Google Drive:**
 - Students will submit their writing assignments via Google Docs (but may also conduct qualitative coding in Google Forms or prepare data for quantitative analysis in Google Sheets, etc).

GRADING

Final grades will be based on a course prep module (various tasks), engagement, three (3) quizzes, four (4) video journal entries, and a final presentation, for a total of 200 points. A +/- grading system will NOT be used.



GRADING/REGRADING POLICY & LATE WORK:

Students who wish for an assignment to be regraded are required to submit a written formal request, stating why the work warrants a higher grade, within seven (7) days of the date when the graded work is returned. Beyond these seven (7) days, assignment will not be regraded. A regrade may result in the same, a higher, or a lower grade - although students requesting a regrade on an assignment often receive a lower grade.

I do not accept late work. In extreme circumstances, I may be willing to grade late work, but written documentation will be required. But this is not a guarantee. Please review Course Policies on Canvas.

30 PTS

COURSE PREPARATION MODULE

During Week 1, students will complete a check of the email policy, their updated profile, and a video introduction about themselves on the class discussion board.

30 PTS

QUIZZES

During the semester, students will complete three (3) quizzes to demonstrate their mastery of the course content.

50 PTS

FINAL PRESENTATION

Students will complete a final presentation that identifies an advocacy organization or nonprofit in San Diego, along with a plan for collaborating with the organization in a way that helps to remedy one social problem covered in the course.

50 PTS

COURSE ENGAGEMENT

Engagement for this class is critical for your overall success, as it allows you to engage with the content related to develop sound research practices.

Engagement entails regular/consistent accessing of the course content (e.g. logging in and accessing the material on Canvas).

40 PTS

VIDEO JOURNAL ENTRIES

During the semester, students will record four (4) video journal entries addressing some topic covered in the course (or reflecting on a current piece of media) that is related to social problems.

These are brief videos where students can document their journey with the material in this course.

ENROLLMENT

PREREQUISITES FOR COURSE:

Current undergraduate standing.

ADDING & DROPPING:

Students must make adjustments to their course schedule by the add/drop deadline indicated in the current term's [Academic Calendars](#).

STUDENT CONDUCT

Please be courteous to your classmates and me by remaining engaged and respectful. Students are expected to conduct themselves in a way that does not interfere with the educational experience of others. Additionally, turn cell phones and other electronic devices on silent during class time.

ACADEMIC (DIS)HONESTY:

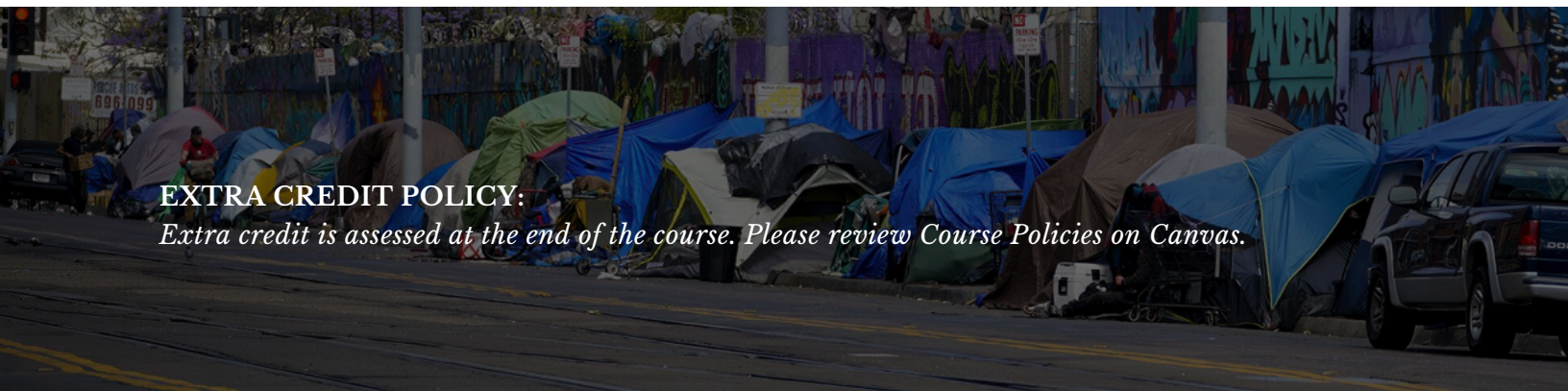
The University adheres to a strict policy regarding [cheating and plagiarism](#) (outlined in [Executive Order 1098](#)). These activities will not be tolerated in this class. Become familiar with the policy and what constitutes plagiarism. Any cheating or plagiarism will result in failing this class and a disciplinary review by the University. These actions may lead to probation, suspension, or expulsion.

Examples of plagiarism include but are not limited to:

- Using sources verbatim or paraphrasing without giving proper attribution (this can include phrases, sentences, paragraphs and/or pages of work)
- Copying and pasting work from an online or offline source directly and calling it your own
- Using information you find from an online or offline source without giving the author credit
- Replacing words or phrases from another source and inserting your own words or phrases
- Submitting a piece of work you did for one class to another class

EXTRA CREDIT POLICY:

Extra credit is assessed at the end of the course. Please review Course Policies on Canvas.



RESOURCES

A complete list of all academic support services is available on the [Academic Success](#) section of the [Student Affairs](#) website.

STUDENTS WITH SPECIAL NEEDS:

Please inform the instructor during the first week of classes about any special needs that require specific arrangements related to attending class sessions, carrying out class assignments, or writing papers or examinations. According to California State University policy, students with “disabilities” must document their special needs at the Student Disability Services (SDS) in order to receive accommodations for their courses. Additional information can be found at the [SDS website](#), by calling [619-594-6473](#), or by email at sds@sdsu.edu.

COUNSELING AND PSYCHOLOGICAL SERVICES (CAPS):

[CAPS](#) offers confidential counseling services by licensed psychologists, counselors, and social workers. More info can be found at their website or by contacting [619-594-5220](#). You can also [Live Chat](#) with a counselor between 4:00pm and 10:00pm, or call San Diego Access and Crisis 24-hour Hotline at [888-724-7240](#).

WRITING CENTER:

For help with improving your writing ability, the staff at the SDSU [Writing Center](#) is available in person and online.

STUDENT TECHNICAL SUPPORT:

Student support for Canvas is provided by the Library Computing Hub, located on the 2nd floor of Love Library. They can be reached at [619-594-3189](#) or by emailing hub@sdsu.edu.

EMERGENCY PREPAREDNESS:

Information about SDSU’s emergency preparedness policy can be found at [Campus Emergency Preparedness](#).

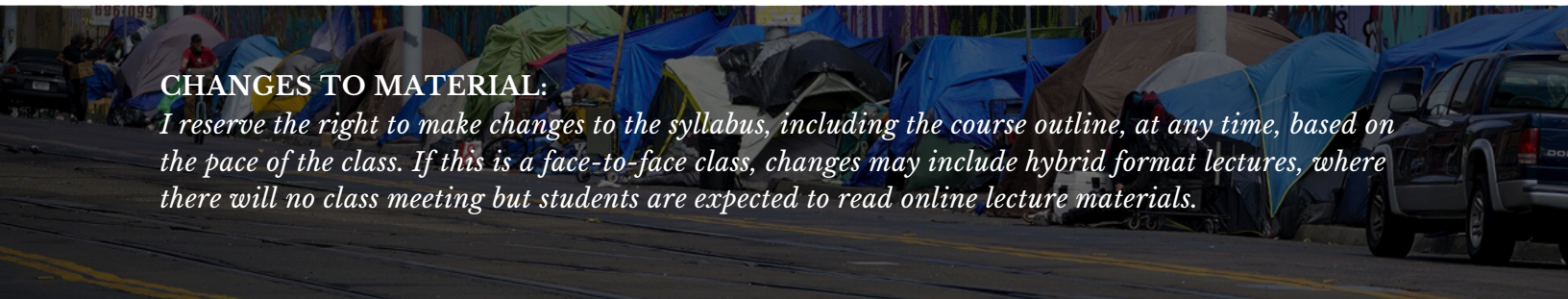
D.E.I.

DIVERSITY, EQUITY, AND INCLUSION:

In this class, through readings, exercises, and activities, we are committed to honoring the diversity of experiences, including but not limited to race, ethnicity, culture, language, sex, gender identity and expression, sexual orientation, national origin, colonial status, immigration status, religion, age, ability, as well as underrepresented, first-generation, veteran, and non-traditional status. Through the inclusion and honoring of diversity, we hope to highlight the ways in which equity can be accomplished.

CHANGES TO MATERIAL:

I reserve the right to make changes to the syllabus, including the course outline, at any time, based on the pace of the class. If this is a face-to-face class, changes may include hybrid format lectures, where there will no class meeting but students are expected to read online lecture materials.



1

MODULE 1

READ/WATCHSyllabus
Module 1 Materials**DUE**Email Policy Check (1/24)
Updated Profile Check (1/24)
Video Introductions (1/24)

JAN 19

INTRODUCTION TO THE COURSE**2**

MODULE 2

READ/WATCH

Ch. 1

DUE

JAN 26

STUDYING SOCIAL PROBLEMS**3**

MODULE 3

READ/WATCH

Ch. 2

DUE

FEB 2

CLASS, WEALTH, POVERTY, AND ECONOMIC INEQUALITY**4**

MODULE 3

READ/WATCH

Ch. 3

DUE

Video Journal #1 (2/14)

FEB 9

RACISM, RACE, AND ETHNIC INEQUALITY**5**

MODULE 3

READ/WATCH

Ch. 4

DUE

FEB 16

SEXISM AND GENDER INEQUALITY**6**

MODULE 3

READ/WATCH

Ch. 5

DUE

FEB 23

HETEROSEXISM AND SEXUALITIES INEQUALITY**7**

MODULE 4

READ/WATCH

Ch. 13

DUE

Quiz #1 (3/7)

MAR 2

CRIME AND THE CRIMINAL JUSTICE SYSTEM**8**

MODULE 4

READ/WATCH**DUE**

Video Journal #2 (3/14)

MAR 9

URBAN, SUBURBAN, AND RURAL INEQUALITY

9

MODULE 5

READ/WATCH
Ch. 12

DUE

MAR 16

ALCOHOL AND DRUG ABUSE

10

MODULE 5

READ/WATCH
Ch. 10

DUE

Quiz #2 (3/28)

MAR 23

PHYSICAL AND MENTAL HEALTH

11

READ/WATCH

DUE

MAR 30

SPRING BREAK (NO CLASS)

12

MODULE 5

READ/WATCH
Ch. 11

DUE

Video Journal #3 (4/11)

APR 6

MEDIA USE AND ACCESS

13

MODULE 5

READ/WATCH
Ch. 11

DUE

APR 13

FAMILIES AND AGING

14

MODULE 5

READ/WATCH
Chs. 6 & 7

DUE

Quiz #3 (4/25)

APR 20

SOCIAL ACTION AND POLITICS

15

MODULE 5

READ/WATCH

DUE

Video Journal #4 (5/2)

APR 27

WRAP UP

16

MODULE 6

READ/WATCH

DUE

Final Presentation (5/11)

MAY 4-11

FINAL PROJECTS
